Kerala's cultural heritage on show

MADRAS, Sept. 11.

A miniature Kerala, depicting the best of its arts and crafts has been created at Lalit Kala Akademi here. The occasion is the "Celebration of Kerala", a 10-day fare, which started today, organised by the Madras Craft Foundation (Dakshinachitra), —a society sponsored by the Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH)—and the Office of the Development Commissioner (Handicrafts), Government of India.

Mrs. Pupul Jayakar, Adviser to the Prime Minister on Cultural and Heritage Resources, who inaugurated performing Arts said, a visit to the exhibition would make people "realise how perfection was present in the kitchens as well as great temples of Kerala".

Mr. Krishna Kumar, Union Deputy Minister for Textiles, who released a brochure congratulated the organisers for bringing out the rich variety of art, culture and heritage of Kerala. Both Mr. Kumar and Mrs. Jayakar emphasised the need to preserve the cultural heritage of the country from the onslaughts of modernism.

Mrs. Jayakar said she was looking forward to a museum which would house great masterpieces of the southern States "however simple in form and fragile". Promising all support from Delhi, she hoped Tamil Nadu which was rich in arts and crafts and of Kerala "where art lived in the lives of the people" would also extend their support.

Mr. V. V. Swaminathan, State Minister for Tourism, formally inaugurated the exhibition. Mrs. Deborah Thiagarajan, president, Madras Craft Foundation, who welcomed the gathering said 22 craftsmen from Kerala would give demonstrations during the celebration period. Mrs. Jaya Menon, of INTACH, presented mementos to the guests. Mrs. Gita Ram, Secretary, Crafts Council of India, proposed a vote of thanks.

As part of the celebration, a food festival has been planned at Hotel Connemara. Handmade panchaloha mirrors (Aranmulla mirrors), Kathakali constume boxes, and matworks are some of the items on display besides photographic depiction of Kerala's architecture.

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